Afghan foreign minister, was asking outright whether Britain would support Afghanistan should a rupture with Russia take place.[113]

The Home government immediately seized on this chance. On 22 April, Dobbs was instructed by Montagu to inform the emir that if he repudiated the treaty signed with Russia, and agreed to consult Britain before embarking on any more foreign agreements, Britain would give him the arms, money and assistance asked for. As the secretary of state explained to Reading:

By such means as these we get our treaty of friendship, in the East we appear as the protector of an independent Moslem State against aggression and...we once again by the act of the Amir get a position of influence, if not of authority, over Afghan foreign relations.

Furthermore, Montagu noted, Curzon was also 'in full agreement with this view'.[114] By the end of April, Montagu reiterated his consent 'to any offer of money and arms, and assurance of support, which the Government of India would be prepared to give to secure [a] complete break with [the] Bolsheviks'.[115]

The new viceroy, however, was sceptical, believing Dobbs was 'unduly optimistic over [the] Afghans' willingness to throw over [the] Russian treaty'.[116] In a long telegram to Montagu, summarising the entire Afghan situation from his point of view, Reading explained the impossibility of completely purging Afghanistan of Bolshevik influence.[117] Even if Amanullah was to overthrow the Russian treaty, this would not necessarily mean the removal of the Soviet representative at Kabul, which would still allow the Bolsheviks to stir up anti-British feeling among the Afghan public. As he reiterated a few days later: